

Inclusive Design

WEBSITES FOR EVERYONE



Website Owner's Manual

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Preface

The Website Owner's Manual is a project management tool. A hub for strategic planning, brand assets, and resources.

Its job is to give owners control over the legal, technical, and business responsibilities they inherit with website ownership.

It does this by providing an ordered checklist of standards to follow.

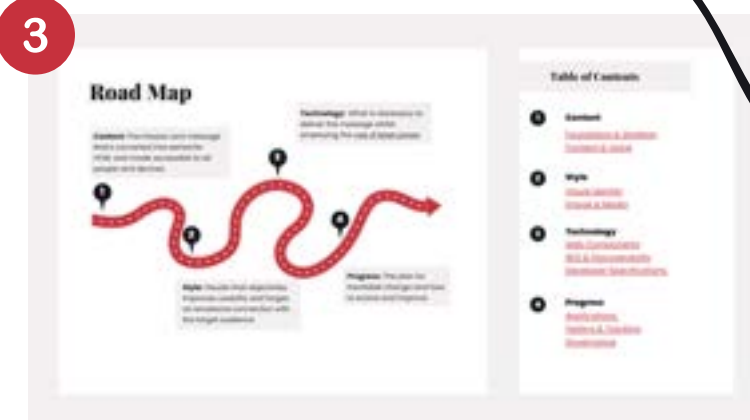
STANDARDS

- [Inclusive Design](#) - Designing for all.
- [Content Design](#) - Meeting needs.
- [Web Standards](#) - Building resilience.
- [Agile Development](#) - Being adaptable.
- [IndieWeb](#) - Taking control.

These are links to short explainer articles on the approach used.

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Principles

Business

- Problem before product.
- Justification before dependencies.
- Local skills before global platforms.
- Simplicity before automation.

Design

- Content before design.
- User needs before stakeholder ego.
- Objectives before personal taste.

Web

- Fluid before fixed units.
- Mobile before desktop.
- Semantics before styling.
- Performance before bloat.
- Accessibility before complexity.

Inclusive design...

- Is a approach that aims to make products, services, and content usable and welcoming for as many different people as possible, across ages, backgrounds, abilities, and contexts.
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- It goes beyond minimum accessibility compliance to actively look for who might be excluded and to remove or reduce those barriers.
- It assumes diversity as the default, not the edge case and is an ongoing mindset, not a one-off checklist.
- It has been adopted by many global corporations, government bodies, and non-profits.



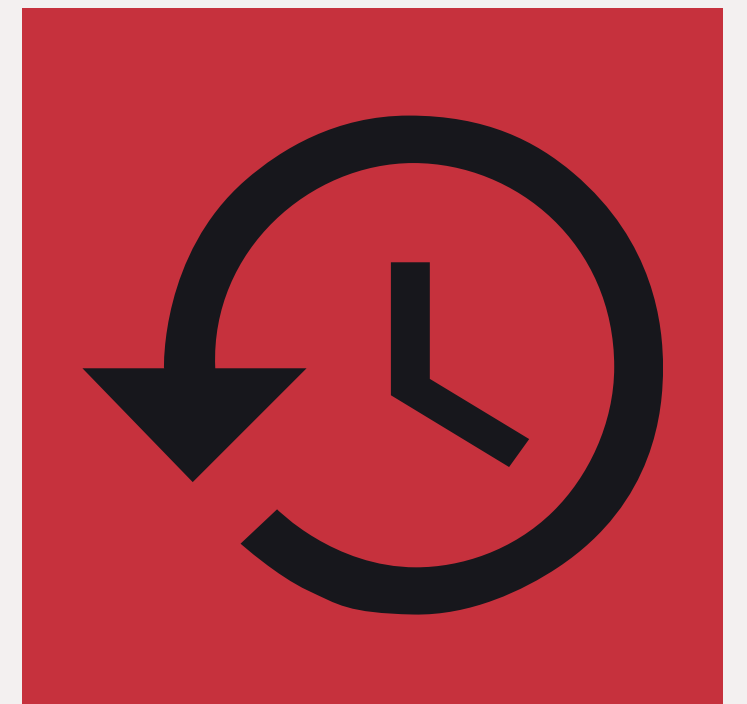
The Historical Evolution

■ **1950s–1960s: Barrier-Free Design.** Removing physical obstacles to help disabled WWII veterans.

■ **1970s: The Social Model of Disability.** This era challenged the "medical model" (which viewed disability as something to be cured). Instead, advocates argued that people are "disabled" by a society that fails to accommodate their needs.

■ **1980s: Universal Design.** This aimed for a single, "one-size-fits-all" solution that works for everyone without needing adaptation.

■ **1990's onward: Inclusive Design.** This acknowledges that multiple variations may be needed to truly include everyone.



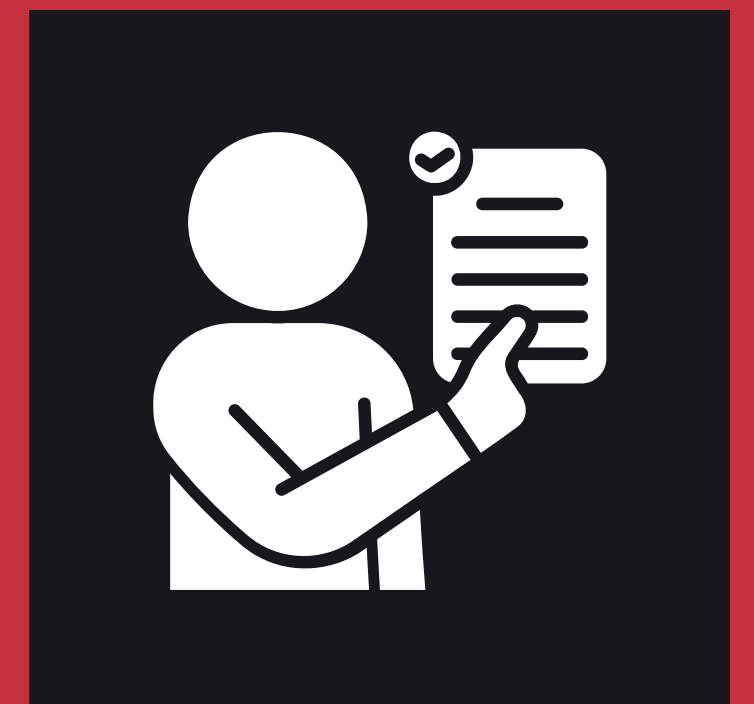
Why it matters

- 2 ■ Designing inclusively strengthens brands by making it easier for more people to find, use, and trust what we offer.
- It supports our ethical commitments, reduces legal and reputational risk
- It often improves the experience for everyone, not just people with specific access needs.
- You start with a competitive edge. 95% don't even manage basic accessibility.



Core principles

- **Equity:** People with different abilities or contexts can complete key tasks with similar ease and dignity.
- **Flexibility:** Interfaces work with different input methods, preferences, and assistive technologies.
- **Clarity:** Content and controls are simple, well-structured, and easy to perceive (e.g., pleasant contrast, clear hierarchy, plain language).
- **Tolerance for error:** The experience helps people avoid mistakes and recover easily when they happen.
- **Participation:** We seek feedback from a diverse range of users and iterate based on what we learn.



How website owners apply this

- Use concise language and explain jargon when it's unavoidable.
- Use meaningful headings, lists, and descriptive link text
- Check actions can be completed with a keyboard and are announced to assistive technologies.
- Alt text for images that convey their purpose.
- Avoid relying on color and maintain sufficient color contrast
- Choose imagery and examples that reflect a variety of people and situations, without tokenism.



How designer apply this

- Inclusive design is about patterns - most exclusion happens through common patterns (nav menus, dialogs, forms, carousels) implemented badly.
- Start from semantics and HTML . Not from visuals.
- Design for variance, not the 'average' user (e.g., hand injury, noisy train, cracked screen)
- Test with assistive tech and real people
- Bake it into the process, not just audits at the end.



References

- Humane Web Manifesto – principles for a more respectful web
- Inclusive Design Principles – people-centred principles for digital interfaces
- 2 • Inclusive Design Guide – an evolving, practice-oriented guide from the Inclusive Design Research Centre
- Microsoft Inclusive Design – guidebooks, tools, and videos on inclusive design practice
- NN/g: Inclusive Design – overview of inclusive design and how it relates to UX and accessibility.

